

2.3.3 Speak

Now this is about how to speak on stage. We'll just iterate the basics.

- First and foremost, do not use a monotone. During your rehearsal, try and see how you can make your speech “more interesting.” If you can do that, you're modulating your voice. You're speaking as the sentence, word, or phrase demands.
- Yes, it is a stage act, but the slides are there. Your speech should complement what's on them. Change your manner of speech in accordance with the material. Taken by itself, what follows might sound silly, but we're only trying to reinforce what you intuitively know: use a powerful tone when opening and closing the presentation. A “thinking” or analytical tone when there are numbers on the screen. A cheerful tone when appropriate. A grand tone when a slide says, “Product x launched in India.” And so on. But never a monotone.
- Speak such that everyone can hear you, that is, ensure your voice reaches those in the back seats. At the same time, don't speak too loud.
- Speak in accordance with who your audience is composed of. Professors? Humility. Company partners? Confidence. Juniors? Authority.
- A simple rule worth remembering: realise when you need to speak louder. Examples are when there is ambient noise, or when you're writing something on the blackboard (if there is one). When you're writing, you tend to speak softer, so you compensate by trying to speak louder... see?
- Pace is important. It is in general a good idea to speak slower than while conversing, so that you're clearer. That said, hold on to two good ideas: change your pace from time to time (as part of the stage act), and speak slower when you want to emphasise a point.